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BREMEN INTERNATIONAL GRADUATE SCHOOL OF SOCIAL SCIENCES

Democracy under threat -

on the psychology of right-wing populism

Ulrich Kühnen

(CU Bremen)

Dora Simunovic

(CU Bremen)

Lusine Grigoryan

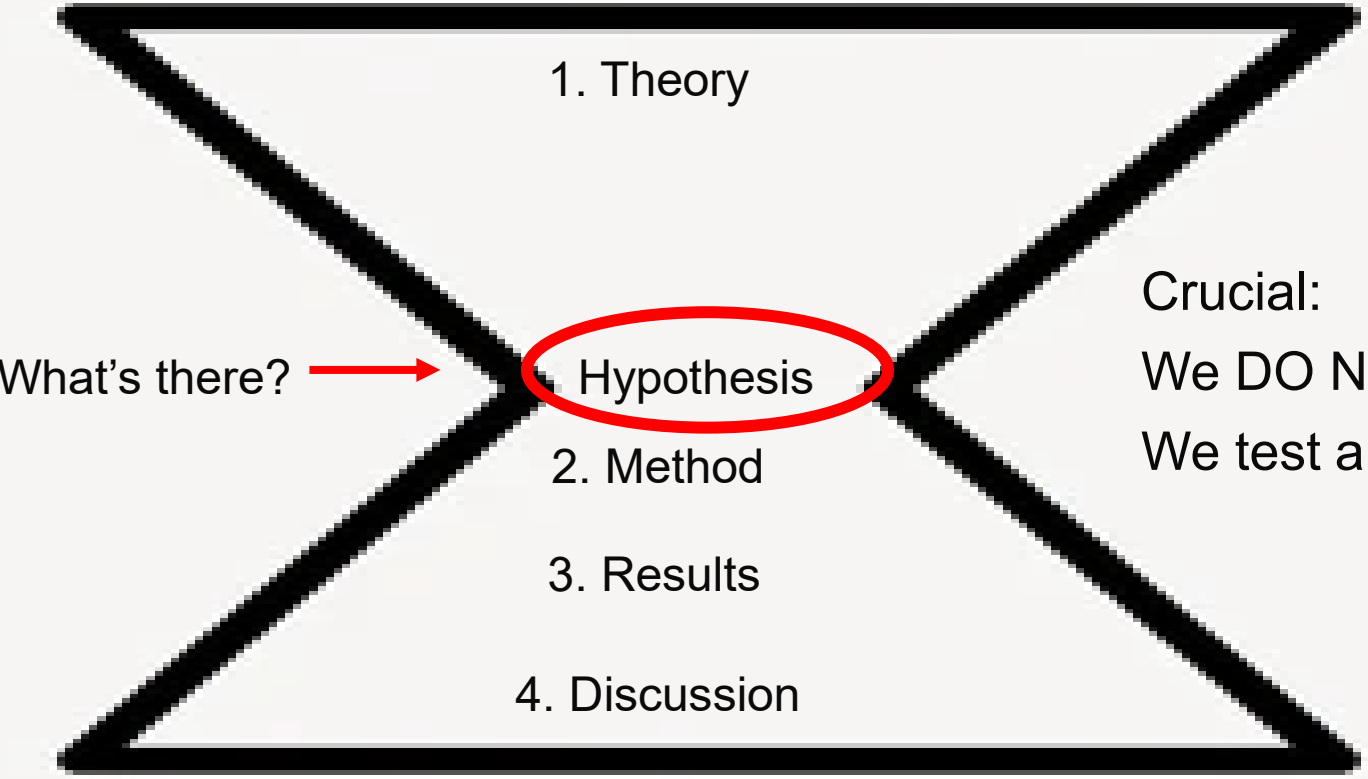
(University of York, UK)

Roy Baumeister

(CU Bremen and Harvard University)

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The scientific journal article



Crucial:

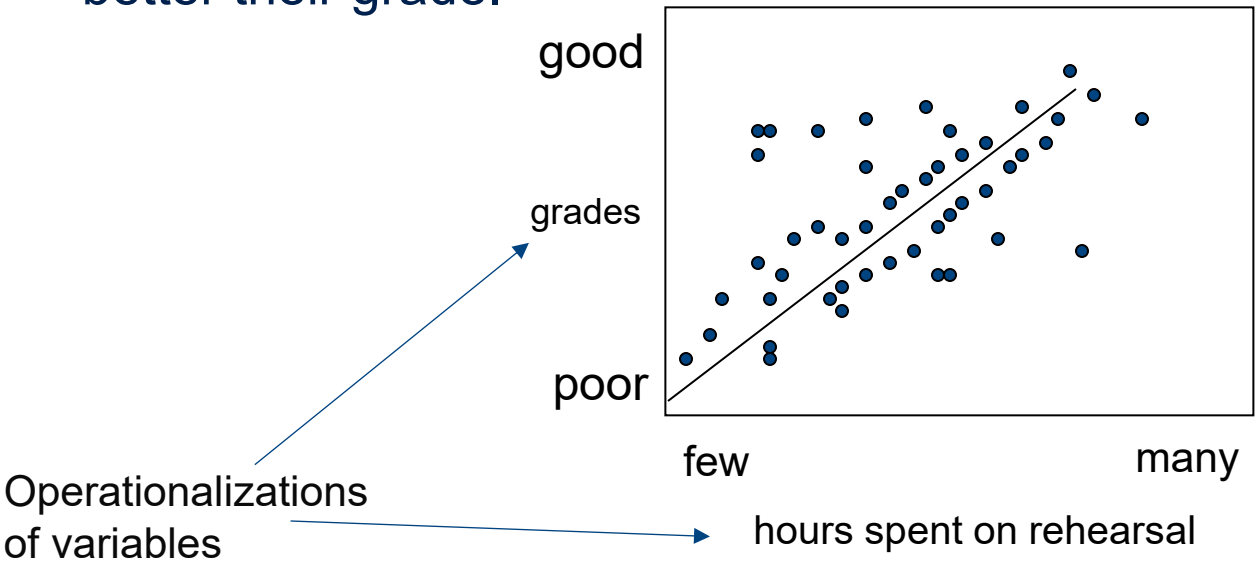
We DO NOT test a theory.

We test a hypothesis.

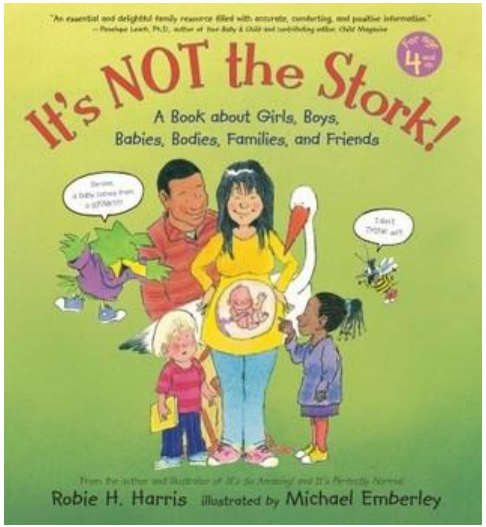
Theory, hypothesis, oprationalization

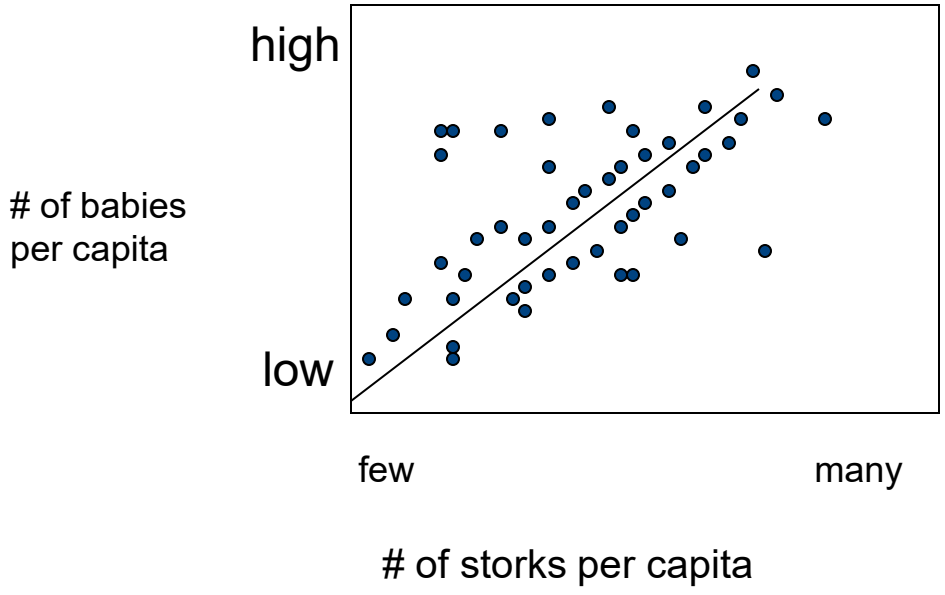
Theory: Rehearsal improves memory.

Hypothesis: The more time students spend on preparing for an exam, the better their grade.



Where do babies come from?




high
low
of babies
per capita
few
many
of storks per capita

Explaining the correlation between storks and babies



Storks (cause) bring babies (effect)

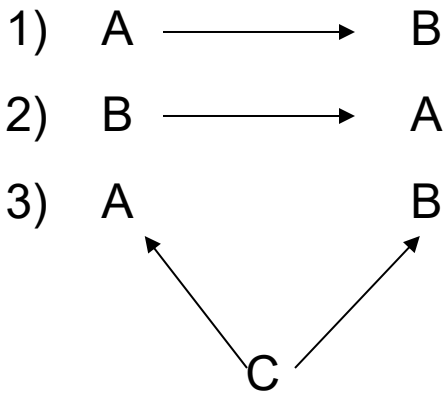


Babies (cause) tell storks where to go (effect)

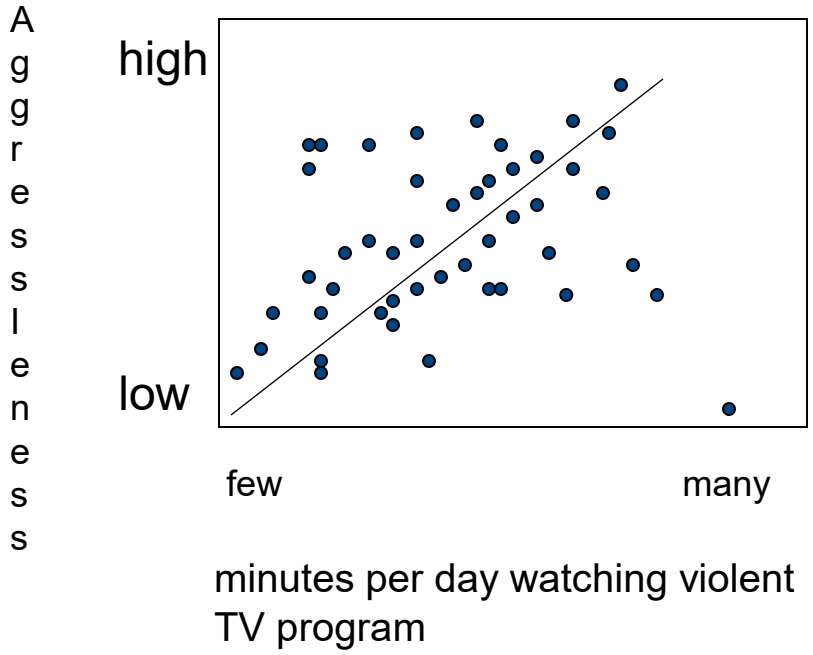


Difference between rural and urban areas coincides with both the # of babies and the # of storks.

Explaining correlations: Three possibilities



Does violent TV consumption cause aggression in children?



Does violent TV consumption cause aggression in children?

Three possible explanations:

1) TV consumption causes aggressive behavior.
2) Aggressive children have few friends and spend more time watching TV.
3) Children from families with ‘troubles’, such as parents who are not very involved in the children’s development, tend to both watch a lot TV and also to behave aggressively.

The experiment

In an experiment, researchers manipulate one or more *independent variables* and examine the effect of these manipulations on one or more *dependent variables*.

Random assignment of research participants to one of the experimental conditions (independent variable) is crucial for drawing causal inferences: All ‘C’ variables that pts bring to the study affect the DV in the same way. If there is still a difference between the conditions, it must be due the IV.

Does violent TV consumption cause aggression in children?

Index for family troubles: 1-no troubles to 10-very many troubles:

Distribution of family troubles in our sample of research participants:

1 1 2 2 2 3 3 3 4 4 4 4 5 5 5 5 5 6 6 6 6 7 7 7 8 8 8 9 9 9 10 10

RANDOM ASSIGMENT

	Condition 1		Condition 2
Distribution of troubles in experimental conditions	1 2 2 3 3 4 4 4 5 5 5 6 6 6 7 8 9 10	=	1 2 2 3 3 4 4 4 5 5 5 6 6 6 7 8 9 10
Independent variable	Watch violent TV		Watch nonviolent TV
Dependent variable	Measure Aggressiveness	>	Measure Aggressiveness

Does violent TV consumption cause aggression in children?

Crucial elements of experiments:

Independent and dependent variables

Random assignment of participants to experimental conditions

Only experiments allow drawing causal conclusions!

Experimental vs correlational research

	Correlational Research	Experimental Research
What does it involve?	Measuring variables and the degree of association between them	Random assignment to conditions and control over the events that occur; determining the effects of manipulations of independent variable(s) on changes in the dependent variable(s).
What is the biggest advantage of using this method?	Enables researchers to study naturally occurring variables, including variables that would be too difficult or unethical to manipulate	Enables researchers to determine cause-and-end relationships – that is, whether the independent variable can cause a change in an experiment in the dependent variable.

Experimental vs correlational research



Internal validity is the extent to which a piece of evidence supports a claim about cause and effect, within the context of a particular study.

External validity is the validity of applying the conclusions of a scientific study outside the context of that study.

Experimental vs correlational research

	Correlational Research	Experimental Research
What does it involve?	Measuring variables and the degree of association between them	Random assignment to conditions and control over the events that occur; determining the effects of manipulations of independent variable(s) on changes in the dependent variable(s).
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→ External validity → Internal validity



Z+ US-Rechtsstaat

So easy, eine Demokratie zu zerstören

Quelle: https://www.zeit.de/kultur/2025-03/us-rechtsstaat-demokratie-verletzlichkeit

MAGA

Trump‘s campaigns and his politics target White Anglo-Saxon Protestants (WASPs)



It‘s about the collective self-image of greatness and dominance

It‘s about a greatness that is declining.

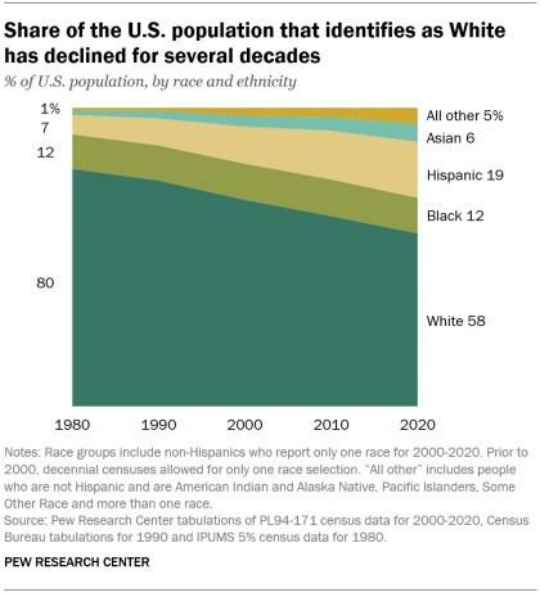
It‘s about the threat of loosing the dominance status.



Protecting the social self-image by derrogating those who threaten it (i.e., former minorities).

Demographic change as threat?





=> Confronting Whites with this change should threaten their social self-image. Expected consequence: Derrogating People of Color

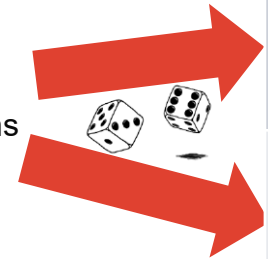
Craig & Richeson (2014)

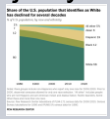
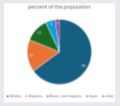
More Diverse Yet Less Tolerant? How the Increasingly Diverse Racial Landscape Affects White Americans' Racial Attitudes

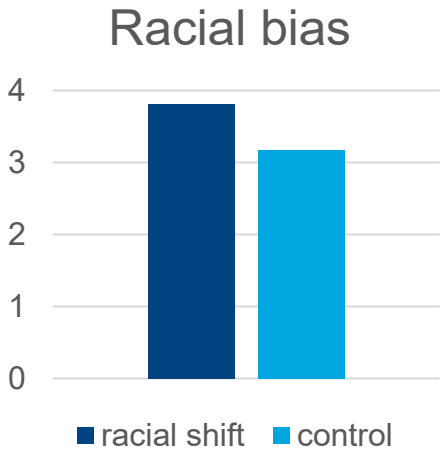
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Maureen A. Craig[1] and Jennifer A. Richeson[1]

White US-Americans



Condition:	„article“	Racial bias
„racial shift“ condition	„In a generation, ethnic minorities may be the US majority.“ 	Agreement with statements such as: „It would bother me, if my child married someone from a different ethnic background.“
Control group	„US Census Bureau releases new estimates of US population by ethnicity“. 	



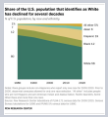
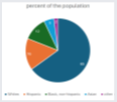
On the Precipice of a "Majority-Minority" America: Perceived Status Threat From the Racial Demographic Shift Affects White Americans' Political Ideology

Psychological Science
1–9
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Maureen A. Craig and Jennifer A. Richeson
Department of Psychology and Institute for Policy Research, Northwestern University

White US participants

=> Independents

Condition:	„article“	Voting tendency
„racial shift“ Bedingung	„In a generation, ethnic minorities may be the US majority.“ 	Which party do you lean toward?
Kontroll-Gruppe	„US Census Bureau releases new estimates of US population by ethnicity“. 	

Craig & Richeson (2014)

Research Article

aps ASSOCIATION FOR PSYCHOLOGICAL SCIENCE

Psychological Science
1–9
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On the Precipice of a "Majority-Minority" America: Perceived Status Threat From the Racial Demographic Shift Affects White Americans' Political Ideology

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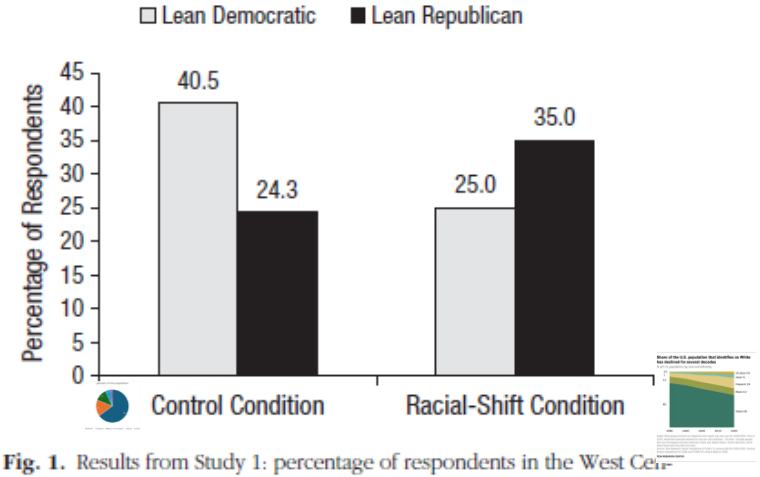


Fig. 1. Results from Study 1: percentage of respondents in the West Census region who leaned Democratic or leaned Republican as a function of condition. Percentages do not add up to 100 because some respondents did not answer the question or indicated that they did not know the answer.

Out study



Quelle: DPA





Quelle: Selbst generiert

- Craig & Richeson published in 2014.

  Does this threat manipulation still work?

- Does high threat cause high authoritarianism (accepting social hierarchies)?

- Does high threat cause “democratic backsliding”?

Online studs with N= 500 white US Americans

JANUARY // #02

JUNIOR ECONOMIST

HIGHLIGHT: TRENDS IN DEMOGRAPHICS

White Americans remain majority group, Census Bureau says

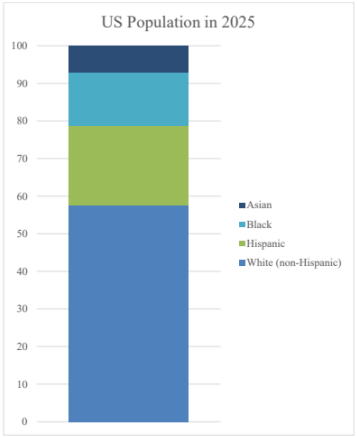
ALLAN GARDNER

JANUARY 20, 2026

The population of the United States continues to change over time. Demographers and social scientists painstakingly record and study these changes, in the hope of better understanding the country's future. Recent census and survey data provide new insights. Overall, the U.S. population is growing, although not evenly across all social and cultural groups. So, who will the Americans of tomorrow be and what sort of America will they create?

(...)

While age and education levels of the population are changing, the ethnic and racial makeup of the country remains considerably more stable. White Americans have historically represented the largest racial and ethnic group in the United States. As the figure on the left shows, they continue to make up a majority of the population today. According to recent estimates from the U.S. Census Bureau, approximately 58% of all Americans identify as non-Hispanic White. Hispanic, Asian, Black, and multiracial populations form a relative minority.



(…)

While the country has become more diverse over recent decades, White Americans remain the largest racial and ethnic group in the United States. Current census data show that they continue to represent a clear majority of the population. Our best projections agree: by mid-century, the country's demographic profile will remain broadly stable.

PAGE 2

JANUARY // #02

JUNIOR ECONOMIST

HIGHLIGHT: TRENDS IN DEMOGRAPHICS

White Americans to lose majority status, Census Bureau says

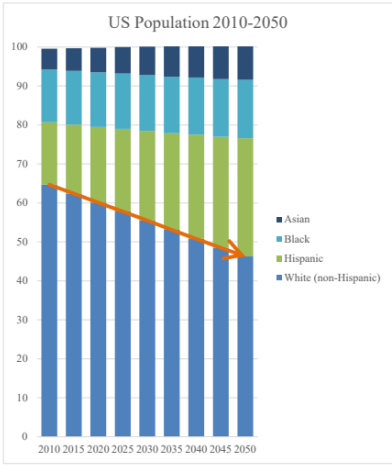
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(...)

It is not only the age and education levels of the population that are changing. The ethnic and racial makeup of the country is also undergoing change. White Americans have historically represented the largest racial and ethnic group in the United States, and continue to make up a majority of the population today. However, according to recent estimates of the U.S. Census Bureau, this will not stay the case for long. As the figure on the left shows, demographic projections suggest that the proportion of White Americans will fall below 50% in the next 20 to 25 years, as Hispanic, Asian, Black, and multiracial populations continue to grow.



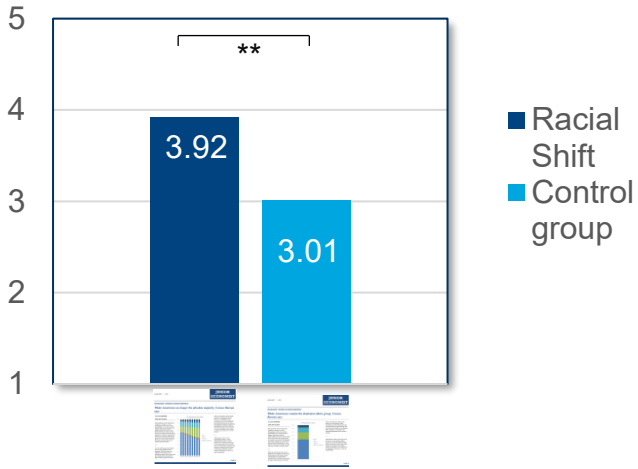
(…)

While the country is still predominantly White, a major demographic transition is on the horizon, set to change the racial and ethnic landscape of the United States. Current census data shows that White Americans will become a minority for the first time in U.S. history within the next few decades. Our best projections agree: by mid-century, the country's demographic profile will look very different.

PAGE 3

Findings

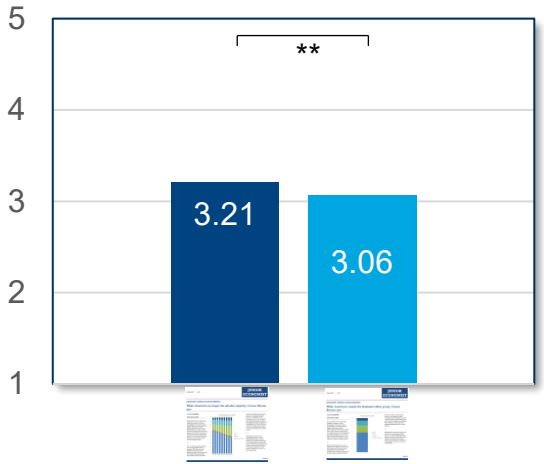
MC: Experience threat



6 Items:

"Reading the article made me feel uncomfortable."

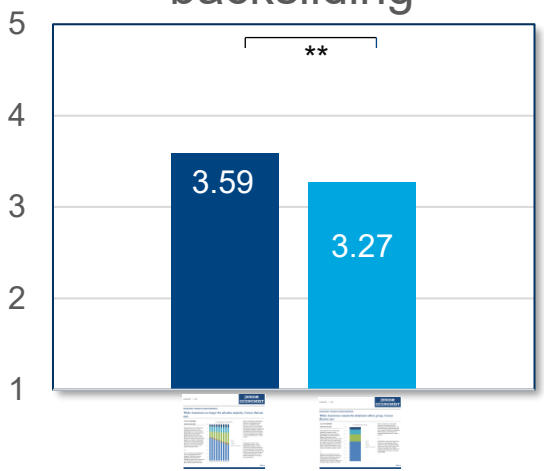
DV: Autoritarianism



8 Items:

"Children have to be shaped by a firm hand."

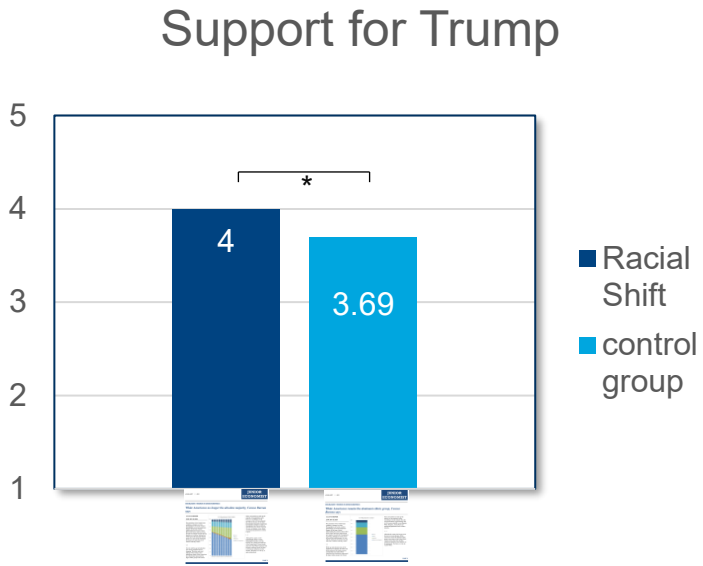
DV: democratic backsliding



8 Items:

"Limit the ability of courts to overturn government decisions in order to ensure policy consistency"; "Restrict criticism of ongoing policy-making efforts in the media"

Findings



“To what extent do you support President Trump?”

(controlled for voting behavior in 2024)

Summary of findings

Right wing populism appeals to fears. In the US, it appeals to White‘s threat of loosing their dominant majority status.



People respond by protecting their self-view through derogating those who threaten their status. By appealing to this threat, Trump can present himself as the ‚savior‘.

Experimental vs correlational research

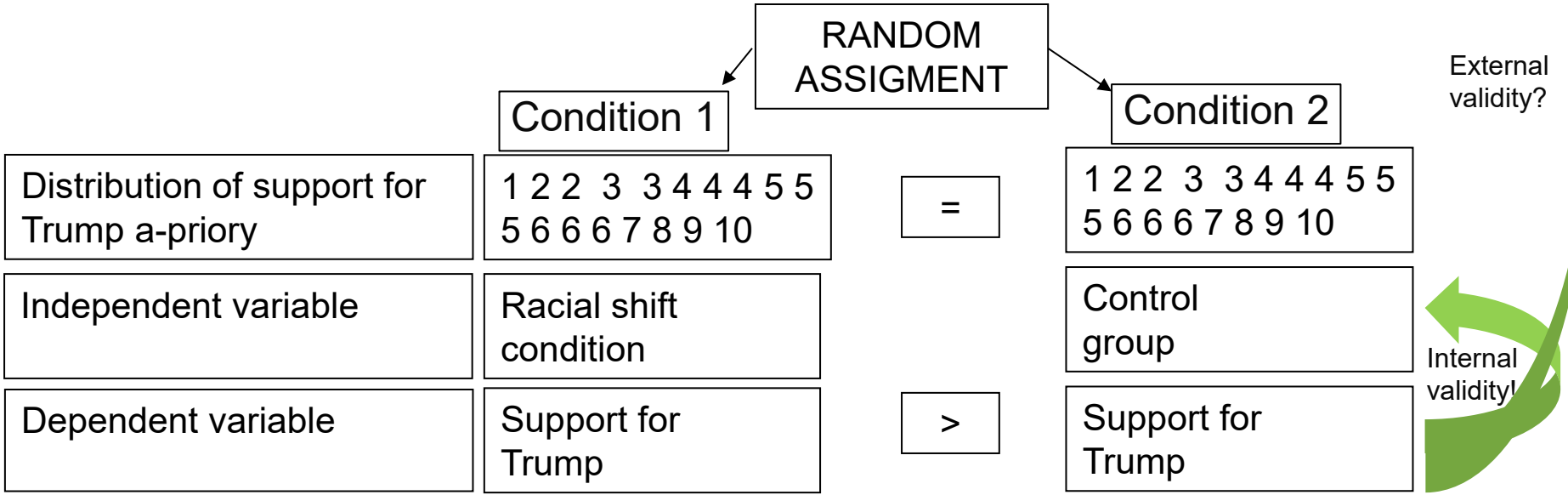
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Does threatening the dominance status of whites in the US increase their support for Trump?

Observation: Trump is strongly supported by Whites. His MAGA campaign appeals to their threat of losing their dominance status.

Theory: Experiencing threat of losing one's dominance status leads to protective responses, including derogation of those who threaten one's self-view. And Trump does exactly that.

Hypothesis: Inducing high threat (rather than low) should lead to stronger support for Trump.



Ende



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Research Training Group
Social Dynamics of the Self

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Themenschwerpunkt: Wie veränderungsbereit ist Deutschland?

